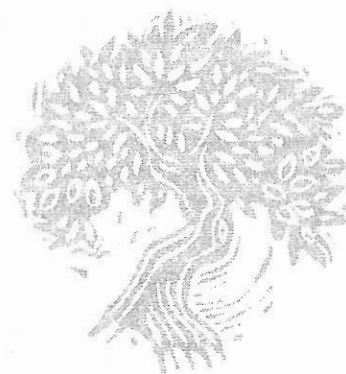


# *The Way of the Lord*

TOM WRIGHT



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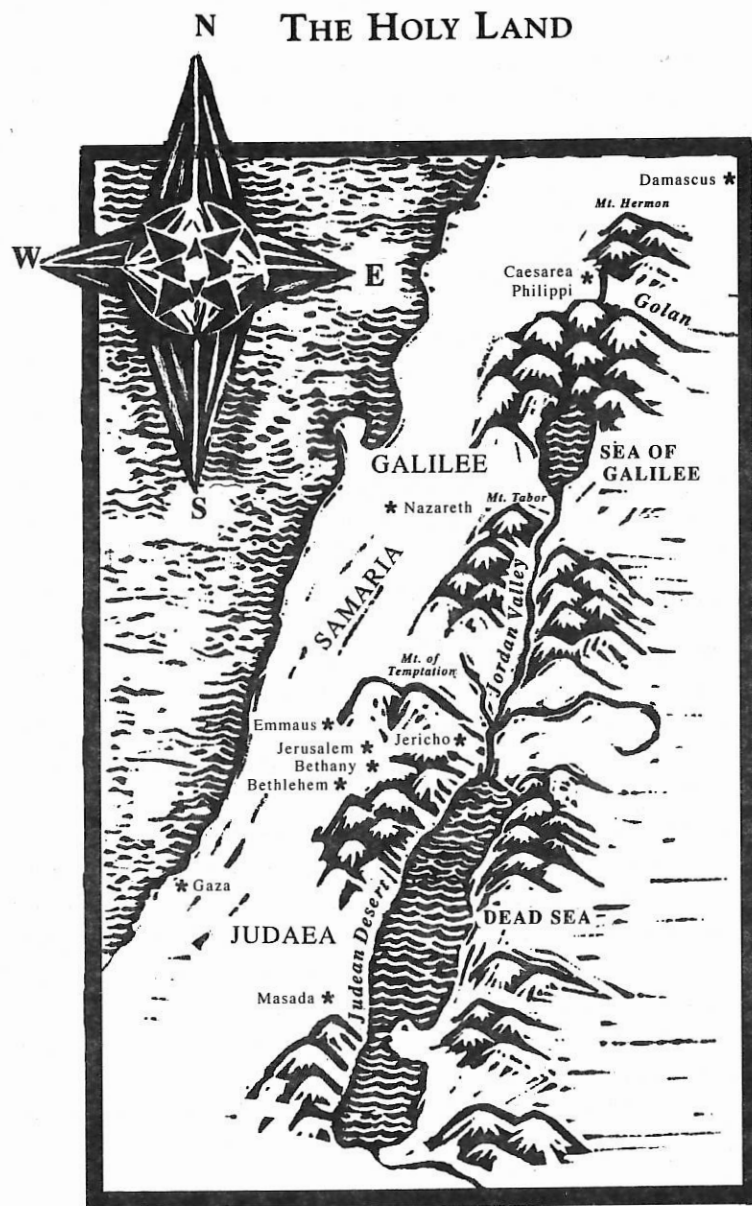
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## *Pilgrimage Today: A Personal Introduction*

CONSIDERING MY OWN origins, it's quite surprising to me now that I didn't get into the idea of pilgrimage a lot sooner.

I was born and bred in central Northumberland, the cradle of early (and pre-Roman) English Christianity. My grandfather was Archdeacon of Lindisfarne, an island which has been a focal point of pilgrimage on and off for nearly 1500 years. Not only, however, did he not live on the island itself; never in my growing years did either the family, or the church which we attended, even consider 'making a pilgrimage' there. We went there once or twice for a day out, in the same way that we would visit Hexham, Alnwick, Bamburgh or the Roman Wall. But there was no specifically Christian or religious aspect to such a visit. One's Christian needs were considered to be well and truly met by regular worship in one's parish church, by reading the Bible and saying one's prayers. What was there to gain by going somewhere else to do the same things? The same applied to visits made from time to time to old monasteries and, indeed, to great cathedrals such as Durham. Full of history and interest, no doubt, but one was no closer to God there than in church at home, or indeed saying one's prayers kneeling beside one's bed.

I suspect there were other influences at work below the

surface. Other types of churches made pilgrimages. Ours, being quietly but firmly of the middle-stump variety, didn't go in for such showy things. And the people who one heard of going on such pilgrimages were not quite our type either. As for the Holy Land itself, sundry relatives had been to the Middle East, during military service or on holiday. They brought back souvenirs, but never talked, at least not to me, about the Christian implications of such a visit. As a result, I don't think I really thought about pilgrimage at all, or considered it a live option. I didn't exactly reject the idea; it just wasn't around as a possibility. Thus, though I lived in one of the great pilgrim areas of England, I knew virtually nothing about it.

This non-consideration of pilgrimage was strongly reinforced by the evangelical teaching I received, and eagerly absorbed, through my teenage years. The reality and warmth of God's presence, the wonder of his personal love for me enacted in Jesus, the aliveness of the Bible, the enjoyment of Christian fellowship and prayer, and the call to follow Jesus and serve him, were quite enough to be going on with. Within the prevailing philosophical climate, to emphasize the 'personal' dimensions of something inclined one to dismiss any 'institutional' dimensions as misleading or unhelpful. Church buildings were regarded as a necessary evil; people had to meet somewhere larger than an ordinary house, but a large tent, or an under-used cinema, was just as good. If I could meet Jesus Christ in a personal way in a marquee in the Scottish highlands, why would I need to go to a church building to continue the experience?

There was a strong sense, indeed, that 'place' and buildings could actually get in the way. People might all too easily suppose that going to a particular place, or going through a particular ritual, might earn you God's favour. That was simply another form of 'works-righteousness', drawing you

away from simple trust in what God had done in Jesus Christ. Pilgrimage spoke of mumbo-jumbo, relics, purgatory and sundry other heresies that the Reformation had thankfully done away with. In some Protestant eyes, Catholic Christians are regularly guilty of idolatry on the one hand and works-righteousness on the other. Idolatry: they worship relics, statues, buildings, reserved sacraments; they even manufacture secondary relics, according (for instance) holy status to objects, such as handkerchiefs, that have come in contact with a saint's tomb. Works-righteousness: they think that by doing certain things, going to certain places, worshipping in particularly holy sites, they will earn God's special favour, in a way that completely undercuts the biblical doctrines of grace and faith.

This way of thinking, as I met it in my teens, claimed strong biblical reinforcement, though at a cost. Had not Jesus said in John's Gospel that true worship was nothing to do with being in Jerusalem or Samaria, but was all about worshipping God in spirit and in truth? The present Jerusalem, Paul had declared, was in bondage with her children; it was the Jerusalem above, the truly free city, who was the mother of us all. This meant, of course, that all sense of continuity with the Old Testament's geographical focus, with the idea of pilgrimage to a holy city, was done away with; as with other aspects of some English evangelicalism, there was always the danger of Marcionism slipping in by the back door, however much one professed to regard the whole Bible as the Word of God. (Marcion, a second-century heretic in Rome, taught that the God of the Jews was not the same as the God revealed in Jesus, and that the Old Testament had nothing much to do with the New.)

Nobody, I think, ever challenged me on this. If they had done, I suspect I would have replied by allegorizing the Old Testament's teaching about pilgrimage, seeking a 'spiritual'

meaning in order to get around the fact that I wasn't taking the literal one seriously. After all, any concern with earthly institutions, let alone making a song and dance about going on pilgrimage to them, was to be seen as part of that all-embracing works-righteousness which the Jews had gone in for, and which Jesus and Paul had opposed. Thus my prejudices, confirmed (so it seemed) on the highest authority, remained intact. I no more contemplated going on pilgrimage than I would have considered kissing the Pope's ring.

It is not easy to describe, let alone account for, the ways in which my mind has changed (about pilgrimage, not about the Pope's ring). A lot has to do with the slow turning away from various forms of dualism, to which evangelicalism is particularly prone, and towards a recognition of the sacramental quality of God's whole created world. Protestantism has regularly down-played the goodness of God's created order, on the good grounds that creation is corruptible, subject to decay, and that if you worship it you become an idolater. Catholicism at its best, however (and I include a lot more than Roman Catholicism under that heading), does not recommend the worship of creation, but the discovery of God at work in creation. With the incarnation itself being the obvious and supreme example, and the gospel sacraments of baptism and eucharist not far behind, one can learn to discover the presence of God not only in the world, as though by a fortunate accident, but *through* the world: particularly through those things that speak of Jesus himself, as baptism and the eucharist so clearly do, and as the lives of holy women and men have done.

Even the cult of relics can be explained, though not (to my mind) fully justified, in terms of the grace of God at work in the actual physical life of a person. Even after their death (so the argument runs) their body can be regarded as a place where special grace and the presence of God were

truly made known. In that light, places where such saints have lived, have built churches, have been buried, become in that sense secondary relics. And, supremely, the places where Jesus himself walked and talked, where he was born, lived, died and rose again, can be seen, and have been seen by some, as effective signs of his presence and love, effective means of his grace.

Reinforcement for this line of thought has come from the surprises I have had when discovering the presence of God in particular places and buildings, in ways I had not expected. In the early 1980s, when we lived in Montreal, my elder son went to a city school which a few years before had purchased from the United Church of Canada a redundant church right opposite the main school building. Being a modern structure, it didn't look much like a church, and they used it for very un-churchlike activities, rock concerts and so forth. The first time we went there, to a very 'secular' occasion, I was stunned. I walked in and sensed the presence of God, gentle but very strong. I sat through the loud concert wondering if I was the only person who felt it, and reflecting on the fact that I had no theology by which to explain why a redundant United church should feel that way. The only answer I have to this day is that when God is known, sought and wrestled with in a place, a memory of that remains, which those who know and love God can pick up. Since then I discovered similar places which I had considered unlikely but which had the same effect.

But the supreme example, in my own life, came on my first visit to the Church of the Holy Sepulchre in Jerusalem. It was 1989. The Arab *Intifada*, the uprising against the Israeli rulers, was at its height. I flew to Israel on Palm Sunday, and spent two or three days settling in, finding my bearings, getting to know how things worked. I deliberately did not go to the Church of the Holy Sepulchre, the church



built over and around the site of Calvary, until Good Friday, when I joined an early morning party walking the Stations of the Cross. I wanted my first visit to the church to be in a context of appropriate worship, not as a tourist. I had been warned, of course, of the two obvious evils which cluster in that remarkable place: competition between different denominations, and commercialization of everything in sight. They were in full evidence. Indeed, as I was standing in contemplation before the very place where Jesus was crucified, I found myself elbowed out of the way by a posse of young Armenian monks, intent on their proper turn to sing an office. But I found a corner of the building with a side-chapel which seemed quiet, away from the noise and bustle; and I stayed there all morning.

And as I thought and prayed in that spot, a few yards from the place where Jesus died, I found that somehow, in a way I still find difficult to describe, all the pain of the world seemed to be gathered there. In the previous days I had seen and heard on the street the anger and pain of the Palestinians. I had seen on other streets the paranoia and painful memories of the Israelis. The very Armenians who had invaded my space carried their own memories of their own genocide, all the worse for being virtually voiceless. So much pain; so many ugly memories; so much anger and frustration and bitterness and sheer human misery. And it was all somehow concentrated on that one spot. And then, as I continued to reflect and pray, the hurts and pains of my own life came up for review, and they too all seemed to gather together with clarity and force in that one place. It was a moment – actually, two or three hours – of great intensity, in which the presence of Jesus the Messiah, at the place where the pain of the world was concentrated, became more and more the central reality. I emerged eventually into the bright sunlight, feeling as though I had been rinsed

out spiritually and emotionally, and understanding – or at least glimpsing – in a new way what it could mean to suppose that one act in one place at one time could somehow draw together the hopes and fears of all the years. I had become a pilgrim.

What I discovered that day, which has stayed with me in the nine years since, is something which less rationalistic people have always appreciated, and less dualistic theologians have always embraced: that places and buildings can and do carry memory, power and hope; and that places where Jesus walked and talked, suffered, died and rose again can and do resonate with the meaning of what he did. If, of course, like the children in C. S. Lewis's Narnia stories, we go into the wardrobe to test it out as it were scientifically, we will find nothing unusual. We will come out grumbling about the commercialization, or the inadequate toilet facilities, or the price of the coffee. But if we go humbly, get down underneath the surface noise, and wait on God in the silence of our hearts, there is no telling what we may hear, what we may discover, in what ways we may be changed.

Have I, then, abandoned my earlier view that the New Testament refuses to countenance any geographical focus to Christian worship and living? No and yes. No: on the one hand, there is no such thing in the New Testament as a Holy Land. In ways that cultures other than our own seem to understand more readily, Jesus' death outside the (then) city walls seems to have brought the Land's holy status to an end. The Father now seeks worshippers from all the world, who will worship him in spirit and in truth. Yes: on the other hand, the world as a whole, and all the countries within it, are now to be regarded as holy. In the book of Acts, the whole world has become the new Holy Land, with the Church playing the role of Joshua to Jesus' Moses, going into this new land to take it captive for its rightful king.

Only, with the change from Holy Land to Holy World there goes a change in the method of its winning. If the crucified and risen Jesus is the Lord of the whole world, the weapons by which his kingdom is established are those of the gospel: suffering and love. And this kingdom will not be fully established until God acts again, finally, to implement fully the achievement of Jesus and thereby to redeem the whole cosmos. That will be the time spoken of in Romans 8, in 1 Corinthians 15 and in Revelation 21 and 22, and for that matter by Isaiah and the other prophets, the time when God will be all in all, when the whole earth shall be full of the knowledge of the Lord as the waters cover the sea. As followers of the risen Christ, we are invited both to contemplate the place where he was and to recognize that there is more to following him than geography. 'Come, see the place' is important, but must be balanced with 'He is not here; he is risen.'

We thereby arrive at what seems to me a characteristically Pauline position of now-and-not-yet. On the one hand, certain places remain special because of their association with Jesus himself, or with one of those who, indwelt by his Spirit, has lived out the life of Christ. On the other hand, the God we know in Jesus claims the entire world, and all its nations, as his own; and wherever this God is worshipped, in an igloo in the Arctic wastes or a mud hut on the equator, in a mighty cathedral or a slum hospital, in that spot another part of God's created space, as well as another moment of God's created time, is quietly claimed as his own. Our Christian living, and our Christian pilgrimages, thus take place in the space and time in between the life of Jesus and God's restoration of the whole creation. Like the sacraments themselves, pilgrimage looks back, in great acts of remembrance, and on to the time of final redemption. And with that reflection we are able once again to use the Old

Testament, with its great theme of the wandering people of God, not merely as allegory for our own spiritual journey, but as the story of the early stage in God's unfolding plan for his world.

These scattered and rambling personal reminiscences hardly amount to a full theology of contemporary pilgrimage, nor do I propose to offer such a thing here. But I want to draw these thoughts together into three propositions about pilgrimage, particularly pilgrimage to the Holy Land, which seem to me worth considering.

So that I am not misunderstood, I preface them with three warnings. First, going to holy places is neither a necessary nor a sufficient condition of being, as one might say, a good Christian. Many saints have never left their native village. Many travellers have come back worse, not better, for the experience. Think of the Crusades. Second, pilgrimage always walks on a tightrope above the abyss of commercialization. This is so whether we are in Lichfield or Jerusalem, Westminster Abbey or the West Bank. That doesn't make it invalid; it does imply that those who organize and look after holy places, and those who visit them, need to be careful about motives. Third, it remains the case that Christianity is not, at its heart, a territorial religion. It is not about conquest of lands and empires, but about God's justice and mercy reaching out to embrace the whole world in Jesus Christ and by the Holy Spirit. I believe that the just and gentle rule of Jesus Christ is vastly more beneficial in its effects on a society that seeks to live under it than any other rule in the world; but precisely this belief also prevents me from mounting military crusades against those who have chosen other ways.

So to my three propositions about pilgrimage today. I take them in ascending order of importance. First, pilgrimage to holy places has a valuable role within the Church's

teaching ministry. Unless you are entirely lacking in imagination, I think you will not return from the Holy Land (and, to a lesser extent, from other historic places of pilgrimage) without fresh insight into all sorts of aspects of the biblical story, particularly the Gospels. You might, in principle, have learnt such things from books, lectures and television; but there is something about simply being there which, for most people, goes to the heart of things. People being taken round the Holy Land frequently say, 'Oh, I see - *that's* what was going on.' The sound of pennies dropping is a frequent accompaniment to Holy Land pilgrimages, and I'm not referring now to commercialization.

Second, pilgrimage to holy places is a stimulus and an invitation to prayer. Those who, like me, share the privilege of worshipping and praying regularly in an ancient holy place know well how those who come are regularly moved to pray by such a building. How much more when we visit the places where Jesus himself lived? One morning in Nazareth I walked up the hill behind the hostel and sat in the early morning sun underneath some very, very old olive trees. It suddenly dawned on me that Jesus had almost certainly climbed the same hill, and played as a boy under the same trees. I cannot describe the sense of intimacy this evoked. I felt as though I could reach out and hug him. Many feel this around the sea of Galilee in particular.

Third, pilgrimage to holy places, though neither necessary nor sufficient for Christian living, can be for many a time of real growth and depth in discipleship. This may have something to do with the sheer fact of travelling away from home, looking for something we don't yet know about. This Abraham-like existence becomes in itself an act of faith, preparing us for and sustaining us in other acts of faith. The letter to the Hebrews speaks of faith as 'the assurance of things hoped for, the evidence of things not seen', and,

in the same passage, describes Abraham and the other saints of old as 'desiring a better country, that is, a heavenly one'. We are invited to join them in this pilgrimage.

This reference to a heavenly country, as I never tire of insisting, doesn't mean that the eventual future home of God's people will be in a disembodied heaven. It means, rather, that God's future reality for the world is at present kept safe in his heavenly sphere, against the day when God will bring the new Jerusalem to birth, coming down from heaven to earth, and thereby joining heaven and earth into one, rather than abolishing the latter by establishing the former. Once we've got that straight, there is every reason to regard the act of pilgrimage in itself as a metaphor, or even a sacrament, for and of the pilgrim's progress through the present life to the life that is to come. Like all sacraments, it is open to the abuse of being treated magically, as though going to a particular place automatically gains you grace, heavenly Brownie points. But the abuse does not remove the use. Our present journey really can become a means of grace, if we approach it in the right way.

My hope and prayer, then, for all who go on pilgrimage, is that they may make right use of their time of journeying: to learn new things, yes; to pray new prayers, yes; but most of all to take fresh steps along the road of discipleship that leads from the earthly city to the city that is to come, whose builder and maker is God. It is in this hope that the present book now invites its readers to follow along the Way of the Lord.

